

JAINS PRAY AT THE
GOPACHAL SIDDHA
KSHETRA

Photographs by RAVI UPADHYAYA

Holding the FORT

The ASI is fighting a tough battle to protect the 8th century Gwalior Fort as many communities stake claim to different parts of the historical structure

By Ambreesh Mishra



For over a millennium, this imposing structure has thwarted the ravages of the elements and marauding armies. But now it seems that the magnificent Gwalior Fort, which dates back to the 8th century, to the reign of Surya Sen, could fall prey to the designs of misguided religious zealots out to encroach parts of the hoary complex. In a recent incident, a huge gathering of the Digambar Jain community swarmed around the foothills of the fort, trying to install a statue of Lord Parsvnath, which they had imported

from Jaipur near the Urvai Gate of the fort protected by the Archeological Survey of India (ASI). They claimed the gate was the site of an ancient temple of Trishala Devi, mother of Lord Mahavir, whose statue in reclining form is engraved on the sheer rock face on which the fort's walls stand.

As ASI officials alerted the district administration, installation of the statue on a newly-constructed platform near the Trishala Devi statue was averted even as the throng of devotees, mostly women, distributed *ladoos* and chanted hymns. Office-bearers of the Trishala Devi Temple Trust, like Vasant Jain, have now promised to reclaim what is historically theirs. "The temple was reduced

to rubble a few decades ago when the fort's walls caved in. We want to reconstruct it," Jain says. The ASI dismisses these assertions. They say no permanent structure, like the one the trust has been trying to build, could be allowed within 100 metre of the area in their custody. When the trust first began to tamper with its monuments five years ago, the ASI had filed a case in a Gwalior court. When the trust restarted the construction of platform and pillars recently, the ASI, on September 25, 2009, moved a contempt application alleging the violation of the court's order to maintain status quo. Last year, some local elements laid claim to the famous Teli Ka Mandir and Saas-Bahu Mandir, saying